

# *The Country of the Blind*

H. G. Wells · 1904

First published: The Strand, Apr 1904

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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# Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

**Edition:** Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Country_of_the_Blind_and_Other_Stories/The_Country_of_the_Blind (revision 15022019), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

**Grades:** Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

## Essential questions

- What does The Country of the Blind suggest about perception and truth?
- What does The Country of the Blind suggest about conformity?
- What does The Country of the Blind suggest about arrogance?

## Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

## Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

**Primary codes:** RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
**Assessments:** Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
**Differentiation:** Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
**Materials:** Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

## The 90-minute lesson

| # | Segment | Mode | Minutes | Clock |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bell-ringer | You do | 8 | 0–8 |
| 2 | Vocabulary with etymology notes | I do | 10 | 8–18 |
| 3 | Background and context | I do | 10 | 18–28 |
| 4 | I do: modeled close reading | I do | 12 | 28–40 |
| 5 | We do: guided annotation | We do | 15 | 40–55 |
| 6 | You do: independent annotation | You do | 15 | 55–70 |
| 7 | Discussion | We do | 10 | 70–80 |
| 8 | Exit ticket / chapter quiz | You do | 7 | 80–87 |
| 9 | Closure | I do | 3 | 87–90 |
| | **Total** | | **90** | |

# Syllabus

| Week | Chapters | Lessons | Focus and activities | Assessment |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | The Country of the Blind | 1 × 90 min (90 min) | *perception and truth*<br>• Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure<br>• Story quizzes in the app<br>• Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week) | Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt |

# Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

# Lesson 1: The Country of the Blind

**Focus:** the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

**Content note (threat of forced surgery):** Sensitive content: Threat of forced surgery. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
**Student preview:** Heads-up: this story includes threat of forced surgery.
**Suggested language:** "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Mountaineer Nunez falls into an isolated Andean valley whose people have been blind for fifteen generations and no longer believe in sight. He expects 'In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King' but is treated as a madman. He falls in love with Medina-saroté; the elders agree to the marriage if his eyes, thought to be diseased, are removed. On the morning of the operation he climbs out of the valley and lies smiling under the stars.

**Background:** Published in The Strand in 1904; the valley's beliefs satirize how communities enforce their own 'truth'.

**Significance:** Often paired with Plato's allegory of the cave in discussing perception and conformity.

*Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)*

**0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
*Settle in and write for five minutes: Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes threat of forced surgery.*

**8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)**
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
*Today's words are converged, cascade, glaciers, avalanche, mockingly. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will." In this sentence it means: came together from different directions. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.*

**18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)**
Present the historical and literary background.
*Here is what the first readers of The Country of the Blind would have known. Published in The Strand in 1904; the valley's beliefs satirize how communities enforce their own 'truth'. Why does this story matter? Often paired with Plato's allegory of the cave in discussing perception and conformity. Write down one question you want answered.*

**28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)**
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
*Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Nunez had an eye for all beautiful things, and it seemed to him that the glow upon the snowfields and glaciers that rose about the valley on every side was the most beautiful thing he had ever seen." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? I circle "glaciers", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.*

**40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)**
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
*Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.*

> *Nunez had an eye for all beautiful things, and it seemed to him that the glow upon the snowfields and glaciers that rose about the valley on every side was the most beautiful thing he had ever seen. His eyes went from that inaccessible glory to the village and irrigated fields, fast sinking into the twilight, and suddenly a wave of emotion took him, and he thanked God from the bottom of his heart that the power of sight had been given him.*

**55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)**
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
*Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Setting, Theme: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Country of the Blind develops the idea of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.*

**70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)**
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
*Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to perception and truth? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.*

**80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)**
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
*Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently, backed by one short quotation.*

**87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
*Today we saw how irony shapes the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.*

Total: 90 minutes.

### *Vocabulary with etymology notes*

| Word | Definition (in this sentence) | In context | Word history |
|---|---|---|---|
| **converged** (verb) | came together from different directions | *He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **cascade** (noun) | a falling mass, like a waterfall | *He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus contents into the deeps of the gorge in a thin and wavering thread of cascade.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **glaciers** (noun) | huge slow-moving masses of ice | *Over mountains and glaciers; right over above there, half-way to the sun.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **avalanche** (noun) | a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain | *He had slipped eastward towards the unknown side of the mountain; far below he had struck a steep slope of snow, and ploughed his way down it in the midst of a snow avalanche.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **mockingly** (adverb) | in a disrespectful jeering manner | *A little boy nipped his hand. "Bogota!" he said mockingly.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **disappointing** (verb) | failing to give someone what they hope for | *But Nunez's manner of receiving the good news struck him as being cold and disappointing.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **simultaneous** (adjective) | occurring or operating at the same time | *They startled him by a simultaneous movement towards him, each with a hand outstretched.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **starlight** (noun) | the light of the stars | *Once at a rest-day gathering they sat side by side in the dim starlight, and the music was sweet.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **civilly** (adverb) | in a civil manner | *And very civilly he gave them greeting.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **precipices** (noun) | a very steep cliff | *The gorge between these precipices ran east and west and was full of the morning sunlight, which lit to the westward the mass of fallen mountain that closed the descending gorge.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |

### *Discussion questions*

1. Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with perception and truth?

### *Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)*

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

#### Literal / recall

1. How does Nunez enter the valley? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He falls during a mountain climb
2. What proverb does Nunez repeat? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King
3. How do the villagers treat his claims about sight? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: As the ravings of a madman
4. Whom does Nunez want to marry? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Medina-saroté
5. What must he give up to marry? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: His eyes
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Country of the Blind” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Mountaineer Nunez falls into an isolated Andean valley whose people have been blind for fifteen generations and no longer believe in sight. He expects 'In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King' but is treated as a madman. He falls in love with Medina-saroté; the elders agree to the marriage if his eyes, thought to be diseased, are removed. On the morning of the operation he climbs out…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Country of the Blind”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Country of the Blind” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.

9. Reread: “He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will.” What does “converged” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: converged: came together from different directions.
10. Reread: “He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus contents into the deeps of the gorge in a thin and wavering thread of cascade.” What does “cascade” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: cascade: a falling mass, like a waterfall.

**Inferential / analytical**

1. What does “The Country of the Blind” suggest about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Often paired with Plato's allegory of the cave in discussing perception and conformity.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. In the passage that begins “Nunez had an eye for all beautiful things, and it seemed to him that the glow upon the snowfields and glaciers that rose about the valley on every side was the most beautiful…”, why might Wells have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Country of the Blind”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Mountaineer Nunez falls into an isolated Andean valley whose people have been blind for fifteen generations and no longer believe in sight. He expects 'In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King' but is treated as a madman. He falls in love with Medina-saroté; the elders agree to the…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Country of the Blind” set up that the rest of The Country of the Blind will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it better to fit in or to keep a truth others reject?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does theme appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with perception and truth? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas.

10. Background: Published in The Strand in 1904; the valley's beliefs satirize how communities enforce their own 'truth'. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

**Evaluative / synthesis / creative**

1. A critic might argue: "Often paired with Plato's allegory of the cave in discussing perception and conformity." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Country of the Blind" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Country of the Blind": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to conformity: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Wells need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Country of the Blind" treats the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Country of the Blind see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve perception and truth? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask H. G. Wells about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

### *Annotation focus*

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Theme**: statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas

### *Chapter quiz*

1. How does Nunez enter the valley?
    A. He is invited
    B. He follows a river
    C. He is captured
    D. He falls during a mountain climb
2. What proverb does Nunez repeat?
    A. Seeing is believing
    B. Love is blind
    C. Pride goes before a fall
    D. In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King
3. How do the villagers treat his claims about sight?
    A. With fear
    B. They make him king
    C. With reverence
    D. As the ravings of a madman
4. Whom does Nunez want to marry?
    A. Yacob's wife
    B. No one
    C. Medina-saroté
    D. A shepherd girl
5. What must he give up to marry?
    A. His eyes
    B. His language
    C. His freedom to climb
    D. His name
6. In the line “He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will.”, what does “converged” most nearly mean?
    A. came together from different directions
    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
    C. a falling mass, like a waterfall
    D. huge slow-moving masses of ice
7. In the line “He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus contents into the deeps of the gorge in a thin and wavering thread of cascade.”, what does “cascade” most nearly mean?
    A. huge slow-moving masses of ice
    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
    C. came together from different directions

D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

**Answer key:** 1. D (He falls during a mountain climb); 2. D (In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King); 3. D (As the ravings of a madman); 4. C (Medina-saroté); 5. A (His eyes); 6. A (came together from different directions); 7. D (a falling mass, like a waterfall)

### *Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)*

**Middle School** (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Country of the Blind," how does Wells show the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

**HS Freshman** (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Country of the Blind, how does Wells develop the idea of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

**HS Sophomore** (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Country of the Blind develops the idea of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Country of the Blind (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

**HS Senior** (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Country of the Blind suggests about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

**AP** (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how H. G. Wells uses irony in The Country of the Blind to complicate the reader's understanding of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

**College Freshman** (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Country of the Blind within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently responds to that context. Engage with at least

one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

**College Sophomore** (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Country of the Blind alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

**College Junior** (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Country of the Blind and its treatment of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

**College Senior** (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Country of the Blind as evidence for a larger claim about the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently in The Country of the Blind. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

**Graduate / PhD** (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Country of the Blind as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Country of the Blind.

### *SAT-style questions*

1. *Over mountains and glaciers; right over above there, half-way to the sun.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “glaciers” most nearly mean?

   A. huge slow-moving masses of ice

   B. a very steep cliff

   C. in a civil manner

   D. the light of the stars

2. *Nunez had an eye for all beautiful things, and it seemed to him that the glow upon the snowfields and glaciers that rose about the valley on every side was the most beautiful thing he had ever seen. His eyes went from that inaccessible glory to the village and irrigated fields, fast sinking into the twilight, and suddenly a wave of emotion took him, and he thanked God from the bottom of his heart that the power of sight had been given him.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Country of the Blind”?

   A. The futile attempt to shut out death

   B. Greed that grasps more than a person needs

   C. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

   D. The hunter becoming the hunted

**SAT key:** 1. A (huge slow-moving masses of ice); 2. C (The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently)

# Whole-book test

**The Country of the Blind: whole-book test** · 90 minutes

## Part I: Multiple choice

1. How does Nunez enter the valley?
   A. He is invited
   B. He follows a river
   C. He is captured
   D. He falls during a mountain climb
2. What proverb does Nunez repeat?
   A. Seeing is believing
   B. Love is blind
   C. Pride goes before a fall
   D. In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King
3. How do the villagers treat his claims about sight?
   A. With fear
   B. They make him king
   C. With reverence
   D. As the ravings of a madman
4. Whom does Nunez want to marry?
   A. Yacob's wife
   B. No one
   C. Medina-saroté
   D. A shepherd girl
5. What must he give up to marry?
   A. His eyes
   B. His language
   C. His freedom to climb
   D. His name
6. In the line “He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upon him. "I'll hit them if they touch me," he swore; "by Heaven, I will.”, what does “converged” most nearly mean?
   A. came together from different directions
   B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   C. a falling mass, like a waterfall
   D. huge slow-moving masses of ice

7. In the line “He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus contents into the deeps of the gorge in a thin and wavering thread of cascade.”, what does “cascade” most nearly mean?
   A. huge slow-moving masses of ice
   B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   C. came together from different directions
   D. a falling mass, like a waterfall
8. As used in the story (“He gripped his spade still tighter, and advanced down the meadows towards the place of habitations, and directly he moved they converged upo”), what does “converged” mean?
   A. came together from different directions
   B. in a disrespectful jeering manner
   C. the light of the stars
   D. a falling mass, like a waterfall
9. As used in the story (“He descended a steep place, and so came to the wall and channel that ran about the valley, near where the latter spouted out its surplus con”), what does “cascade” mean?
   A. failing to give someone what they hope for
   B. a falling mass, like a waterfall
   C. in a civil manner
   D. huge slow-moving masses of ice
10. As used in the story (“Over mountains and glaciers; right over above there, half-way to the sun.”), what does “glaciers” mean?
    A. occurring or operating at the same time
    B. a very steep cliff
    C. huge slow-moving masses of ice
    D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
11. As used in the story (“He had slipped eastward towards the unknown side of the mountain; far below he had struck a steep slope of snow, and ploughed his way down i”), what does “avalanche” mean?
    A. the light of the stars
    B. came together from different directions
    C. in a disrespectful jeering manner
    D. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
12. As used in the story (“A little boy nipped his hand. "Bogota!" he said mockingly.”), what does “mockingly” mean?
    A. in a disrespectful jeering manner
    B. in a civil manner
    C. a falling mass, like a waterfall
    D. failing to give someone what they hope for

## Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how perception and truth develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how conformity develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how arrogance develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

## Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (perception and truth, conformity, arrogance) and argue how the ending reframes it.

## Answer key

**Answer key:** 1. D (He falls during a mountain climb); 2. D (In the Country of the Blind the One-eyed Man is King); 3. D (As the ravings of a madman); 4. C (Medina-saroté); 5. A (His eyes); 6. A (came together from different directions); 7. D (a falling mass, like a waterfall); 8. A (came together from different directions); 9. B (a falling mass, like a waterfall); 10. C (huge slow-moving masses of ice); 11. D (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain); 12. A (in a disrespectful jeering manner)

# Essay assignments

## Essay: Perception and truth

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Country of the Blind teaches about perception and truth. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how H. G. Wells develops perception and truth in The Country of the Blind. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how H. G. Wells develops perception and truth across The Country of the Blind. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Country of the Blind (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of perception and truth. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of perception and truth in The Country of the Blind. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how H. G. Wells's choices in The Country of the Blind (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of perception and truth, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Country of the Blind's treatment of perception and truth in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on perception and truth in The Country of the Blind that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on perception and truth in The Country of the Blind. Name your

critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about perception and truth in The Country of the Blind, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on perception and truth in The Country of the Blind, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Conformity

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Country of the Blind teaches about conformity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how H. G. Wells develops conformity in The Country of the Blind. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how H. G. Wells develops conformity across The Country of the Blind. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Country of the Blind (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of conformity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of conformity in The Country of the Blind. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how H. G. Wells's choices in The Country of the Blind (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of conformity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Country of the Blind's treatment of conformity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on conformity in The Country of the Blind that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on conformity in The Country of the Blind. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about conformity in The Country of the Blind, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on conformity in The Country of the Blind, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Arrogance

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Country of the Blind teaches about arrogance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how H. G. Wells develops arrogance in The Country of the Blind. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how H. G. Wells develops arrogance across The Country of the Blind. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Country of the Blind (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of arrogance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of arrogance in The Country of the Blind. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how H. G. Wells's choices in The Country of the Blind (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of arrogance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Country of the Blind's treatment of arrogance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on arrogance in The Country of the Blind that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on arrogance in The Country of the Blind. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about arrogance in The Country of the Blind, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on arrogance in The Country of the Blind, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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